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CAPTAINCY AND CHAOS

THE ATTACK on the Sri Lankan team bus in Lahore had some influence on our winning the 2009 World T20. Strike that. It had *everything* to do with our win.

As a team, we were already under pressure in the tournament, having lost to England and the Lankans in the group stages itself.

Slowly, there was a revival of sorts. First, individual performances started to peak. For example, Umar Gul's spell against New Zealand (3–0–6–5) was wonderful. In the same match, I took a crazy running catch to get Scott Styris out when he was looking dangerous at 22, all set to take the Kiwis home. I still remember that catch – my God, running towards the long-on boundary. That dismissal was the turnaround moment for Pakistan – we all knew it. That moment was the game changer.

The surge in performances continued. Against South Africa, the best match of the series, I played an out-of-character 50. Before that game, I had been written off by most critics. By the time it was halfway, I was blowing flying kisses to Jacques Kallis after every pull shot I got off his bowling. The secret, for me, was batting up the order, at number three. I remember, after that New Zealand game, I'd gone to Younis and just flat out asked him to promote me up the order. He didn't cross-examine my request. I think my tone made it very clear to him what I wanted to do. It was like a warriors' pact: we were all in the mood to take risks. We were all feeling, playing, breathing a bit differently. So when I smashed Kallis all around and then dispatched Johan Botha for four successive boundaries, my captain and I knew exactly what I was up to. When it came to bowling, I dismissed Herschelle Gibbs and AB de Villiers, bowling them through their gate.

You see, for the first time in a long time, I was playing with abandon. I was free emotionally. I remember telling Indian commentator Harsha Bhogle that I wasn't taking pressure anymore. Pakistan had hit rock bottom. International cricket had literally been gunned out of our country. Thus, in the last two matches of the tournament, I just felt different. I was batting with a whole different mindset. After years, I was talking to myself, out there in the middle. I knew this was a